Growing up in Germany, I was shaped by an educational tradition that, in response to the difficult historical experiences of the twentieth century, places extraordinary emphasis on critical thinking and questioning assumptions. One of my most formative experiences involved a history class built around interpreting propaganda material from the Weimar Republic in the form of a cartoon depicting the Treaty of Versailles as a noose around Germany's neck. The exercise required students to analyze the symbolism, place it within the historical context of the time, and crucially defend our interpretations in class discussion. Listening to how others approached the same image expanded my understanding in ways that solitary study never could. This experience planted a conviction that guides my teaching today. In an era where artificial intelligence can generate factual answers in seconds, the true value of education lies in learning to think critically, question assumptions, and apply understanding to unfamiliar problems. My teaching guides students towards these skills by employing three core principles: teaching students the foundational tools to think critically, applying course materials to current examples that stimulate genuine student interest, and fostering an inclusive environment that encourages dialogue and engagement with the ideas of others.

Consider the example of my Week 1 Section in the Economics and Statistics (Econ 5) course. I introduce concepts like mean and median by drawing Santa Barbara's income distribution on the whiteboard and ask students what would happen if LeBron James relocated here. Students quickly calculate that the mean income would rise substantially while the median barely moves. The deeper point lands with force: whether a news article uses the mean or the median can fundamentally alter its conclusions in the presence of outliers. What follows is one of the liveliest discussions of the quarter, as students identify other domains such as income inequality and housing costs where the same distinction carries weight. By the end, students actively question which statistic is being reported in the news, and why that choice matters.

Connecting this nascent critical thinking to real-world applications is just as essential to prepare students for life outside the university. Drawing on my background in finance, I walk Financial Management (Econ 134A) students through a discounted cash flow valuation Excel model of Nvidia that I created myself. This is the kind of analysis a financial analyst performs daily. The exercise is designed to give students exposure

to tasks they might be asked about in job interviews and to demonstrate how sensitive a stock's valuation is to its underlying model assumptions. For example, I adjust the discount rate, the rate at which investors value future cash flows relative to current earnings, by a single percentage point. That small shift alone can flip a stock's rating from "Hold" to "Buy". Students are visibly struck by the impact of such a small change, and in the weeks that follow, I see a steady stream of office-hour visits from students eager to stress test the assumptions in their own projects. To me, this is a promising sign that critical thinking is taking root.

Creating an inclusive environment in which every student feels empowered to engage and participate in class discussions is essential. Drawing on my own experience as a non-native speaker in my undergraduate classes, students were often asked by TAs to answer section questions seat-by-seat. Rather than listening to and absorbing my classmates' answers, I spent most of my mental energy rehearsing my own answer to speak coherently in front of the other students. As a result, I learned far less from those discussions than I should have. That experience showed me that forced participation can actually reduce the engagement it is intended to promote. In my teaching, I make it clear from day one that I do not cold-call students. Instead, I look for every chance to encourage students and offer guiding hints when they are stuck. Throughout the quarter, I watch students who initially sat quietly begin volunteering their thoughts, having built confidence through positive interactions rather than being thrust into the spotlight before they are ready.

Beyond the classroom, I am exploring how game-based learning can deepen student engagement and understanding of economic concepts. For example, I am developing an interactive simulation in which students act as a gold mine operator, deciding on the optimal ratio of capital to labor to employ given a production function. This is a classic economic question that is taught in textbooks in an abstract way. Rather than teaching students about the theory behind returns to scale, the simulation interface allows them to experiment with different input combinations, build intuition through play, and progressively tackle harder problems. This reflects what I believe teaching looks like at its best: building intuitive understanding of course material that empowers students beyond the classroom, connecting it to the world they inhabit, and doing so in an environment where every student is free to grow.